

AI Media vs Polar Bears : Taste-Washing

USA West

The Premise

Youth feel guilty enjoying AI Media bc of its Environmental Implications. However, they also use AI regularly. Meanwhile tech companies are adopting artisanal aesthetics, fashion, to appear more human, cool, and trustworthy to Gen Z consumers.

Why is this important?

Generative AI is measurably worse for the climate than traditional digital habits. Gen Z knows this (thank God) but is uniquely conflicted bc they use and like AI but are extremely worried about the environment.

73% are "extremely worried" about climate (GlobeScan/BBMG 2024)

62% felt anxious in the past month (Deloitte 2024)

Gen Z is the only cohort where concern about AI's environmental impact spikes. 49% extremely/very concerned vs. 37% of all Americans (Verasight, July 2025).

93% of Gen Z report using AI at work, and the Ghibli-fication trend added a million users to ChatGPT in a single hour. GlobeScan + 3

Chan (2025) in *Education and Information Technologies* validated an AI guilt instrument with three dimensions: perceived laziness/inauthenticity, fear of judgment, and identity/self-efficacy concerns.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

Ecological Awareness and Anxiety is greater in the youth and spreading.

Psychological Safety

Who, what, where when takes the hit. AI is being used and consumed but in the context of passive enjoyment, entertainment and art it creates more tension.

Brand Trust and Taste-washing aesthetics will have a fine line to walk.

Key statistics / quotes

High school Jr at magnet art school in Texas, “My friends, we don’t really like AI, they actually hate AI. My Dad loves AI.”

SF D&DP in person hang: “I love AI but if I could push a button and make it all go away I would” “Me too, if I could do it for everyone all at once” “me three” “yeah” -4th One abstained.

LA Entertainment Consultant : "AI enhanced faces are making new talent irrelevant, the safest bet long term being an ugly face...Old face is the new hire-able”

Oakland based Comic Artist: “I don’t know what my position is on AI yet. I know I can’t use it in my art or I would lose my fan base and I know what my colleagues position is on it but I need to make up my own mind. I am interested to know how I can use to for other parts of my business.”

San Altman “People talk about how much energy it takes to train an AI model – but it also takes a lot of energy to train a human...It takes about 20 years of life – and all the food you consume during that time – before you become smart.” Despite that defense, he said that the public assessment of AI’s energy consumption was “fair”, adding: “We need to move towards nuclear or wind and solar very quickly.”
<https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2026/feb/23/sam-altman-openai-energy-use-datacenters>

Why did the studio pick this one?

West is home to LA media scene and SF home to AI scene. Both scenes also, at least on the individual consumerism level, highly favor ecologically responsible luxury goods and services.

Taste-washing is the new green-washing but different because it comes after work that is not as easy to commodify as code, it comes after our brain and our aesthetic resistance. Its also reminiscent of Fashwave which was a case of a far-right project successfully wearing a left-or-neutral-coded aesthetic.

Greg Brockman (OpenAI President): "Taste is a new core skill."

Paul Graham (Y Combinator): in an AI age "taste will become even more important."

Koen Bok (Framer founder): those with "great taste" will build the next great products.

Anthropic spokesperson to Axios (April 2026), describing Claude Opus 4.7: outputs "align better with what an experienced practitioner in that domain would consider great work" — i.e., the company is now marketing taste as a model capability.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients?

Just yesterday I used AI to make a video for a fashion brand whose consumers value ecology, look like it was hand crafted with felt. I wasn’t sure how I felt.